

LEAVE

Leave and Absence Policy

Annual, sick, parental and special leave entitlements across all Meridian Group entities.

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Document Control

This policy is maintained by the document owner named on the cover page. It is reviewed at least annually, and earlier where legislation, regulation or business circumstances require. Employees are notified of material changes by email and through the employee self-service portal.

Version	Date	Owner	Summary of change
1.0	2019-06-01	Head of HR	Initial issue covering UAE entities only.
2.0	2022-01-01	Head of HR	Extended to Saudi Arabia and Egypt entities.
2.4	2024-03-01	Head of HR	India entity added; study leave introduced.
3.0	2025-01-01	Head of HR	Leave tier structure replaced flat entitlement.
3.1	2026-01-01	Head of HR	Carry-forward cap standardised at 10 days across all tiers.

Purpose

This policy sets out the paid and unpaid leave available to Meridian Group employees, the basis on which entitlement is calculated, and the process for requesting and approving absence.

It exists so that entitlement is applied consistently across every entity in the Group, so that managers have a clear basis for approval decisions, and so that employees can establish their own entitlement without needing to ask.

Scope

This policy applies to all employees of Meridian Group and its subsidiary entities in the United Arab Emirates, Saudi Arabia, Egypt and India, regardless of employment type.

Entitlement varies by **leave tier** and by **country of employment**. An employee's leave tier is determined by their job grade, as set out in the Compensation and Grading Framework (POL-HR-004). Country of employment is the country of the legal entity that employs the individual, not the country in which they are physically working on any given day.

Contractors engaged through third-party agencies are covered by the terms of their agency agreement and not by this policy.

1. Annual Leave

Annual leave entitlement is determined by leave tier and country of employment. The table below states the full annual entitlement for a full-time employee completing a full calendar year of service.

Leave tier	Applicable grades	United Arab Emirates	Saudi Arabia	Egypt	India
Tier 1	G1, G2	20 days	20 days	18 days	18 days
Tier 2	G3, G4, G5	25 days	25 days	23 days	23 days
Tier 3	G6, G7	28 days	28 days	26 days	26 days
Executive	G8, G9	30 days	30 days	28 days	28 days

1.1 Accrual

Annual leave accrues monthly at one twelfth of the full annual entitlement, from the first day of employment. Employees may take accrued leave during their probationary period with the approval of their line manager, but may not take leave in advance of accrual.

Employees who join or leave part-way through a calendar year receive entitlement pro-rated to the nearest half day, calculated on completed months of service.

1.2 Carry-forward

A maximum of **10 days** of unused annual leave may be carried forward into the following calendar year. This limit applies to every tier and every country. Carried-forward days must be taken by **31 March** of the following year, after which they lapse without payment.

Carry-forward is capped at 10 days for all employees. Days above this cap are forfeited at 31 December. Employees are responsible for planning their leave to avoid forfeiture; managers must not refuse reasonable leave requests that would cause an employee to lose entitlement.

1.3 Public holidays during leave

Where a public holiday recognised in the employee's country of employment falls within a period of approved annual leave, that day is **not** deducted from the

employee's annual leave balance. The recognised public holiday calendar for each country is published on the employee self-service portal at the start of each year.

1.4 Weekends

The standard working week differs by country. In the United Arab Emirates, Saudi Arabia and Egypt the weekend falls on **Friday and Saturday**. In India the weekend falls on **Saturday and Sunday**. Weekend days falling within a leave period are not deducted from the annual leave balance.

2. Leave Types

The following leave types are available across the Group. Availability, evidence requirements and maximum durations are set out below.

Leave type	Code	Paid	Evidence required	Maximum consecutive
Annual Leave	AL	Yes	No	30 days
Sick Leave	SL	Yes	Yes	90 days
Maternity Leave	ML	Yes	Yes	90 days
Paternity Leave	PL	Yes	Yes	5 days
Compassionate Leave	CL	Yes	No	5 days
Unpaid Leave	UL	No	No	60 days
Hajj Leave	HL	Yes	Yes	30 days
Study Leave	STL	Yes	Yes	10 days
Work From Home	WFH	Yes	No	5 days
Emergency Leave	EL	Yes	No	3 days

2.1 Entitlement by country

The table below states entitlement for a Tier 2 employee. Sick, parental and special leave entitlements do not vary by tier; only annual leave varies by tier.

Leave type	United Arab Emirates	Saudi Arabia	Egypt	India
Sick Leave	60 days	60 days	60 days	60 days
Maternity Leave	60 days	60 days	90 days	90 days
Paternity Leave	5 days	5 days	5 days	5 days
Compassionate Leave	5 days	5 days	5 days	5 days
Hajj Leave	30 days	30 days	30 days	30 days
Study Leave	10 days	10 days	10 days	10 days
Emergency Leave	3 days	3 days	3 days	3 days
Unpaid Leave	60 days	60 days	60 days	60 days

3. Sick Leave

Employees are entitled to up to **60 days** of sick leave in any twelve-month period. Sick leave is paid on a graduated basis:

Period	Payment
First 15 days	Full pay
Days 16 to 45	Half pay
Days 46 to 60	Unpaid

A medical certificate from a licensed practitioner is required for any absence exceeding **two consecutive working days**. Certificates must be submitted through the self-service portal within three working days of returning to work.

Sick leave is not deducted from annual leave. An employee who falls ill during a period of approved annual leave may convert the affected days to sick leave on production of a medical certificate covering those dates.

4. Parental Leave

4.1 Maternity leave

Maternity leave entitlement is **60 calendar days** for employees of the UAE and Saudi Arabia entities, and **90 calendar days** for employees of the Egypt and India entities, reflecting the statutory minimum in each jurisdiction.

Maternity leave is paid at full salary. Employees must give at least 30 days notice of the intended start date and provide a medical certificate confirming the expected date of delivery. Leave may commence up to 30 days before the expected date of delivery.

On return to work, employees are entitled to nursing breaks of one hour per working day for six months from the date of delivery, taken at a time agreed with the line manager.

4.2 Paternity leave

Employees are entitled to **5 working days** of paid paternity leave, to be taken within six months of the date of birth. A copy of the birth certificate is required.

5. Special Leave

5.1 Compassionate leave

Up to **5 working days** of paid compassionate leave is available on the death of a spouse, child, parent, sibling, grandparent or grandchild. Additional unpaid leave may be approved at the discretion of the department head where travel is required.

5.2 Hajj leave

Muslim employees are entitled to **30 calendar days** of paid Hajj leave **once during their entire period of service** with Meridian Group. Proof of pilgrimage booking is required. This entitlement cannot be carried forward, exchanged or paid in lieu.

5.3 Study leave

Up to **10 working days** per calendar year of paid study leave is available for examinations relating to a qualification approved under the Learning and Development Policy (POL-HR-012). Examination timetables must be submitted with the request.

5.4 Emergency leave

Up to **3 working days** per calendar year of paid emergency leave is available for urgent, unforeseeable personal circumstances. Emergency leave may be notified retrospectively but must be logged in the system within two working days of return.

5.5 Unpaid leave

Up to **60 calendar days** of unpaid leave may be approved in exceptional circumstances, and requires the approval of both the department head and Human Resources. All accrued paid leave must be exhausted first.

Unpaid leave affects end of service entitlement. Periods of unpaid leave do not count as service for the purpose of gratuity calculation under the End of Service and Gratuity Policy (POL-HR-009), and salary is deducted at one thirtieth of monthly gross pay for each day of unpaid absence.

6. Requesting Leave

1. Submit the request through the employee self-service portal, selecting the correct leave type.
2. Provide the required supporting evidence where the leave type demands it.
3. The line manager reviews the request and either approves or rejects it, recording a reason where the request is rejected.
4. Approved leave is deducted from the relevant balance on the first day of absence.
5. Where a request is rejected, the employee may escalate to the department head, and thereafter to Human Resources.

6.1 Notice periods for requests

Duration of leave	Minimum notice
1 to 2 working days	2 working days
3 to 5 working days	7 calendar days
6 to 10 working days	21 calendar days
More than 10 working days	30 calendar days

6.2 Grounds for rejection

A manager may reject a leave request only on reasonable operational grounds. Recognised grounds are: insufficient accrued balance; team coverage unavailable for the requested period; conflict with a committed project delivery milestone; a declared blackout period; or insufficient notice under section 6.1. A reason must be recorded in every case.

Blackout periods. Finance may declare a blackout on the last five working days and first three working days of each quarter. Customer Success may declare a blackout during a major client go-live. Blackouts must be published at least 30 days in advance.

Questions and Support

Questions about this policy should be raised with Head of Human Resources through the HR service desk on the employee self-service portal, or by email to

hr.support@meridiangroup.com. Where this policy conflicts with mandatory local law in any jurisdiction in which Meridian Group operates, local law prevails and the document owner must be notified so that a country addendum can be issued.